

GitHub - Contributing to DataFlex Libraries

Date: 2026-06-01

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Overview

DataFlex Libraries have long been distributed through our company official website, providing developers with reliable and supported solutions. As the DataFlex community continues to grow, we want to make it easier for developers to participate directly in the evolution of these libraries.

Moving library development to GitHub provides several benefits:

- **Faster fixes and improvements** - community members can contribute bug fixes and enhancements without waiting for official product release cycles
- **Direct developer participation** - developers can submit improvements, new functionality, and optimizations based on real-world experience and evolving needs
- **Version flexibility** - organizations may adopt fixes and enhancements that are compatible with their specific DataFlex version without having to wait for an official library update
- **Broader perspectives** - contributions from a diverse community bring new ideas, approaches, and solutions that make the libraries better for everyone
- **Improved transparency** - development discussions, issue tracking, and code changes are visible to the community
- **Collaborative innovation** - developers can build upon each other's work and help shape the future direction of the DataFlex libraries

Our goal is to create a space where active developers can easily collaborate, share expertise, and help shape and improve the DataFlex tools available to the community.

If you are interested in taking part in it, continue reading – there are some guidelines to follow in order to make working as a team manageable, and contributing great code a breeze.

DataFlex Download Center

The current DataFlex Download Center remains available at:

<https://download.dataflex.dev/>

The Download Center will continue to list and allow developers to download existing libraries released for DataFlex 25.0 and earlier. Product libraries (like LibXL and Froala) will remain on the Download Center for other versions of DataFlex as well.

Going forward, however, public library installation and/or zip files will no longer be updated and released on the Download Center. Only updates to product libraries (like LibXL and Froala) will be done on the Download Center.

On public libraries' pages, we will include the link to the GitHub repository holding the latest library source code lives. Developers may, then, download the library from there.

To recap:

- Existing downloads will remain available through the Download Center
- For public libraries, new fixes, enhancements, and community contributions will be published through GitHub
- Developers are encouraged to obtain the latest version of those libraries directly from the corresponding GitHub repositories
- Library updates should not be expected on the Download Center any longer, unless for product libraries

DataFlex on GitHub

DataFlex Public libraries, also known as open source, are hosted on GitHub at <https://github.com/DataFlex-dev>

DataFlex-dev is home to those libraries' repositories. They contain sample projects, documentation, and source code. Those repositories may be reviewed and are open to community-driven contributions.

Access Requirements

To participate, you will need:

- A GitHub account
- Basic familiarity with Git and GitHub workflows

All public libraries are, well, public and do not require any special permission to be accessed. You may download and inspect all source code right away.

Finding Libraries

On DataFlex-dev, you may access a list of available repositories on the Repositories tab on the main page. Each repository contains:

- Source code
- Documentation
- Issue tracking
- Contribution guidelines
- Release information

Before contributing, review the repository's README and any repository-specific contribution instructions.

New to GitHub?

If you are unfamiliar with GitHub, the following resources provide an excellent introduction:

- GitHub Skills – Introduction to GitHub
<https://github.com/skills/introduction-to-github>
- Hello World
<https://docs.github.com/en/get-started/start-your-journey/hello-world>
- Get started with GitHub documentation
<https://docs.github.com/en/get-started>

These learning resources cover repositories, branches, commits, pull requests, and collaboration workflows.

Reporting Issues

All proposed changes should begin with an issue and you must always create an issue before implementing a fix or new feature – that helps to keep track of changes and:

- Avoid duplicate work
- Ensure proposed changes align with project goals
- Allow maintainers to provide guidance before development begins
- Facilitate discussion and design decisions

Bug Reports

When reporting a bug, include:

- DataFlex version
- Library version or commit reference
- Operating system and environment details
- Clear description of the problem
- Steps to reproduce the issue
- Expected behavior
- Actual behavior
- Screenshots, logs, or sample code when applicable

Feature Requests and Suggestions

When proposing a new feature or improvement, include:

- Description of the proposed improvement

- Business or technical problem being solved
- Expected benefits
- Potential implementation considerations
- Example usage scenarios

Issue Review Process

After an issue is submitted:

1. The lead maintainer of the library will review it
2. Additional information may be requested and will be communicated through comments on the issue page
3. The maintainer will determine whether the issue should be implemented or not. Determination will also be communicated on GitHub
4. Approved issues may be assigned, prioritized, or opened for community contribution

Please wait for feedback before investing significant development effort in large enhancements that you proposed for the public version of the library.

Remember that you may always create your own local version of the library if any proposed change is not approved. However, keep in mind that if you do that, future updates to the public version of the library might be more complex for you to incorporate into your local, private code.

Contributing to DataFlex Libraries

Once an issue has been reviewed and accepted, development work can begin.

Typical Contribution Workflow

1. Create or identify an approved issue
2. Fork the repository (if required)
3. Create a branch dedicated to the issue
4. Implement the changes
5. Test the changes thoroughly
6. Commit changes with clear commit messages and test information
7. Submit a pull request referencing the related issue

Linking Changes to an Issue

Every pull request should reference the issue it addresses. So, when opening a pull request, please include:

- Issue number
- Summary of the change

- Description of the implementation
- Testing performed
- Any known limitations or considerations

Coding and Documentation Expectations

Contributions should:

- Follow existing coding conventions – Hungarian notation
- Include appropriate comments where necessary
- Maintain backward compatibility whenever practical
- Update documentation when functionality changes
- Include examples when introducing new features

Pull Request Review

After submission:

- The lead maintainer will review the open pull request
- Feedback or requested modifications may be provided
- Additional testing may be requested
- Once approved, the contribution will be merged into the public repository

Review times may vary depending on the complexity of the change and maintainer availability. Contributors should generally expect several business days for initial review, although larger contributions may require additional time.

Using Your Changes Immediately

One of the major benefits of GitHub-based development is that you do not need to wait for a pull request to be approved and merged before benefiting from your work.

You may decide to:

- Fork a library repository
- Apply your fixes or enhancements
- Use your version directly within your own development environment
- Continue development while the review process is underway

This allows you to address immediate needs while still contributing improvements back to the DataFlex developer community.

Resources

The following links provide some additional guidance on contributing to Git projects in general that apply to our public/open-source libraries:

- Git Basics
<https://docs.github.com/en/get-started/git-basics>
- Git Cheat Sheet
<https://training.github.com/downloads/github-git-cheat-sheet/>
- First Contributions
<https://github.com/firstcontributions/first-contributions>
- What is Hungarian Notation and Why should I use it?
<https://www.lenovo.com/gb/en/glossary/what-is-hungarian-notation/>
- DataFlex Naming Conventions
https://docs.dataflex.dev/LanguageGuide/Naming_Conventions/

Conclusion

GitHub provides a modern and collaborative platform for developing and maintaining DataFlex libraries. By enabling direct community participation, we can deliver improvements faster, encourage innovation, and make library development more transparent and accessible.

Whether you are reporting issues, submitting bug fixes, proposing enhancements, or sharing entirely new ideas, your contributions help strengthen the DataFlex presence and speed up DataFlex development for everyone.

If you have questions about any of the processes described in this guide, please contact the maintainers of the relevant repository (refer to the library Readme for that) or reach out through the appropriate DataFlex community channels – our Contact form (<https://www.dataflex.dev/about/contact-266>), online forums (<https://support.dataaccess.com/forums>), or HDE (<https://hde.dataflex.dev>).

We also encourage developers to create and publish their own DataFlex libraries, frameworks, utilities, and sample projects on GitHub. Expanding the amount of publicly available DataFlex source code increases visibility for the language, encourages knowledge sharing, and helps both new and experienced developers discover solutions that can benefit the entire community.

Thank you for your contributions and for helping build a stronger, more collaborative future for the development of DataFlex applications.